Richard B. Root

American biologist and ecologist Richard Root was born in Dearborn, Michigan, in 1936. He grew up on a farm, exploring nature and longing to know “how the woods worked.” By the time he completed his doctorate at the University of Michigan, Root was already a knowledgeable ecologist. His 1967 thesis on the Blue-gray Gnatcatcher, in which he introduced the key concept of the guild, cemented his reputation. Root was invited to join the staff of Cornell University, where he taught biology and ecology. While there, he researched the relationship between arthropods (a large group of invertebrates including insects and arachnids) and goldenrod flowers. Root received many awards during his career, including the Ecological Society of America’s Eminent Ecologist award in 2003 and its Odum award in 2004.